

Verify Before You Trust

Five checks that take under two minutes combined. Run them every session, on every number that matters. This is the difference between using AI like a professional and hoping like a tourist.

1 Formula, not a value

Ask: `Show me the formula behind that total.`

Copilot sometimes writes a static number where a formula belongs. The static number is correct today and silently wrong the day a row changes.

2 Tie one number to source

Pick the grand total. Trace it to the raw rows yourself, once per session.

One independent tie-out catches whole classes of error: filtered ranges, dropped rows, a table it quietly ignored.

3 Run it twice

Same prompt, fresh run. Compare the two answers.

Output is non-deterministic. Same numbers in a different shape is normal. Different numbers is your cue to stop and check the work.

4 Keys as Text

Format identifier columns (CUSIPs, account numbers) as Text before anything else touches them.

Numeric formatting eats leading zeros silently. 067901108 becomes 67901108, joins stop matching, and nothing warns you.

5 It reads your hidden tabs

Keep answer keys, drafts, and anything sensitive in a separate, closed workbook.

Everything in the open workbook is context, hidden or not. The pane can quote a tab you forgot was there.

WHEN IT STALLS: THE RECOVERY LADDER

1. **Re-run the same prompt.** Non-determinism cuts both ways; second runs often land.
2. **Switch models and re-run.** Same prompt, different engine. Budget extra time for thinking models.
3. **Do it by hand.** Know the manual path before you need it. The AI is a speed layer, never the only way you know how.

Copilot is a junior analyst who is very fast at reading tables and writing formulas, and who needs you to check every number, catch every corporate action, and sign off on every conclusion.